



semifinals in multiple European Cup/Champions League campaigns.

Inter's back three — Francesco Acerbi, Alessandro Bastoni, and Stefan de Vrij — anchor the defence, with Bastoni operating as a modern libero. When not in possession, Inter drops into a compact mid-block designed to regain the ball and trigger grounded counters.

If that fails, midfielders Hakan Calhanoglu and Henrikh Mkhitaryan drop into a deeper role, forming a seven-man low block focused more on clearances than recoveries. Forwards Lautaro Martinez and Marcus Thuram stay ready to exploit space on the break.

Inter leads the UCL in clearances and is second in offsides forced. Bastoni, the side's key distributor, has completed the most passes (658) and ranks second in ball recoveries (57) among his teammates.

In attack, while full-backs push forward, one midfielder stays back to maintain a four-man defensive line and guard against counters.

Goalkeeper Yann Sommer, signed

as a low-cost replacement for Andre Onana, has been pivotal. He holds the most clean sheets (7) in this UCL campaign and made 14 saves over two semifinal legs to eliminate Barcelona, earning Player of the Match in the second leg.

Inter has also dominated aerial duels, winning 53.81% — the highest among clubs in Europe's major leagues. PSV Eindhoven (52.85%) and PSG (51.16%) follow. However, Inter's structure leaves space near the flanks. If the full-backs are pulled out of shape, the wide channels become vulnerable — an issue Barcelona exposed with two goals from the left and one from the right.

A fitting final

The expanded UCL format drew scepticism at the start, with concerns over a diluted competitive standard. But after 187 matches, those doubts have faded. Munich will now host a compelling final between two tactically disciplined sides — it's a case of an unstoppable force versus an immovable object.

Inter Milan's road to final



League Phase

Finished in 4th place

Knockout Stages

Round of 16 (Advanced 4-1 on aggregate)

2-0 win at Feyenoord

2-1 win vs Feyenoord at home

Quarterfinals (Advanced 4-3 on aggregate)

2-1 win at Bayern Munich

2-2 draw vs Bayern Munich at home

Semifinals (Advanced 7-6 on aggregate)

3-3 draw at FC Barcelona

4-3 win vs FC Barcelona at home

PSG's road to final



League Phase

Finished in 15th place (outside automatic knockout qualification)

Knockout Stages

Playoff Round (Advanced 10-0 on aggregate)

3-0 win at Stade Brestois 29

7-0 win vs Stade Brestois 29 at home

Round of 16 (Advanced 1-1 on aggregate, 4-1 on penalties)

1-0 loss vs Liverpool at home

1-0 win at Liverpool (4-1 on penalties)

Quarterfinals (Advanced 5-4 on aggregate)

3-1 win vs Aston Villa at home

3-2 loss at Aston Villa

Semifinals (Advanced 3-1 on aggregate)

1-0 win at Arsenal

2-1 win vs Arsenal at home